Without doubt, the most moving read of my year was *The Line of Mercy: A Novel* (HarperCollins India) by Tarun J. Tejpal. It is such a beautifully over-the-top product of sagesse, swag, wryness and chuckle. The media stonewalling of one of the most polyphonic "India books" ever to come out is emblematic of the poverty and herd-mentality that marks intellectual life in India today. The loss is ours. The book has a date with history.

I was, until this year, not able to afford the luxury that is the two-volume compendium *Amrita Sher-Gil* (Tulika Books), edited by Vivan Sundaram. What emerges through the letters, photos and art is a playful, peppery young woman with the confidence to laugh at convention, who lived and worked in an epoch of giants and held her own. The tragedy and unfulfilled potential is known. But what spoke to my bones was Sher-Gil's passion and her assertion of a globe-straddling Indianness of persona and artistic themes.

A revelation and delight was a ginormous graphic novel chanced upon at Blossom Book Store, Bangalore. *The Osamu Tezuka Story : A Life in Manga and Anime* (Stone Bridge Press) by Toshio Ban is as much a history of Japan as it is a history of the art form Tezuka was such an iconic practitioner of.

Also recommended is *Dreaming with His Eyes Open: A Life of Diego Rivera* (Alfred A. Knopf) by Patrick Marnham. The times, the politics, the crossings and love affairs between (well and badly-matched) luminaries, the luscious work that came out of it all...

On its way to me right now is Vikramajit Ram's *Mansur* (Pan Macmillan), a novel based on Jehangir's favourite court painter, the man responsible for the earliest colour depiction of the Dodo. ■

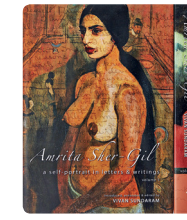
BOOKMARKS

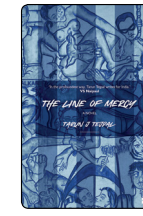
Strokes of Genius



Amruta Patil *is a painter and author of four graphic novels, including* ***Aranyaka*** *(2019). She is currently working on her fifth!*

AMRITA SHER-GIL
Edited by Vivan Sundaram

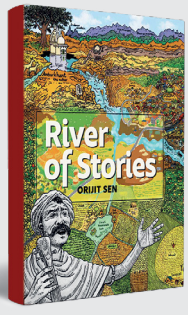




THE LINE OF MERCY: A NOVEL
by Tarun J. Tejpal



THE OSAMU TEZUKA STORY
by Toshio Ban



RIVER OF STORIES
Illustrations and text: Orijit Sen
BLAFT PUBLICATIONS
₹795; 78 pages



After the Flood

In this deeply moving retelling, artist **Orijit Sen** traces the controversial history of the Narmada dam project

Though the book was delivered to me for review as a PDF version, I ran right out and bought a physical copy. It's that kind of book—it needs to be held in the hands, smelled, listened to.

This slender hardback is a reprint, produced with care on the 25th anniversary of its first edition. It has been called a graphic novel, but "allegorical documentary" might be a more appropriate term. It tells the story of a movement, a river, a giant dam and a nation in conflict with itself. In the book, the river is the Rewa. In the real world, the river is—or was—the Narmada. As author-activist Arundhati Roy says in her eloquent foreword, the river has today been reduced to a mere trickle.

Sen writes in his introduction that he was "beset by doubts" about presenting a new generation of readers with the story of what might be considered a failed movement against the building of a dam. But Paul Gravett, comics historian and curator, in a second foreword reminds us that the "images and words in a printed comic, however, do not go away", that "these stories, these voices, these ideas, these questions persist—and they resist, and they insist."

The book begins with Vishnu, a young journalist who sets out on his first assignment to cover a people's movement against the building of a dam. Before he leaves home, however, he interviews Relku, an Adivasi woman. She tells him of the brutality with which forest dwellers are forced off their ancestral lands. Her narrative provides a platform for the character of Malgu Gayan, the singer-storyteller whose voice is woven into the book.

Sen's artwork is as superb as his command over the medium. He tells a complex story with wonderful economy. The drawings are dense and detailed but not at the expense of narrative flow. Overlapping scenes are intercut with a film director's sense of style and drama. The rich palette of character "types" avoids caricatures in preference for well-observed quirks of expression and costume.

But let us not forget that this is a tale of outrageous tragedy, told through pictures. The violence perpetrated by one group over another in the name of progress matches the colonial era. Sen's greatest achievement, in my opinion, is his willingness to let the tragedy dominate, rather than the rage. Unlike other great artist-memorialists such as Joe Sacco and Art Spiegelman, whose images are terrifying, Sen channels a wry, philosophical sadness. Like Malgu Gayan, he sings instead of screaming. He reminds us of that older India, of the friendly people, of the teeming forests and rivers. And he invites us to dream of a better future than the sad, polluted travesty we have today. ■

Manjula Padmanabhan